

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – BREAK, BREAK, BREAK

by
Alfred, Lord Tennyson

- About the Poem
- Paraphrasing
- Rhyming Scheme
- Figures of Speech
- Theme
- Questions & Answers

About the Poem

"Break, Break, Break" is a short elegiac poem by Alfred, Lord Tennyson, written around 1835 and published in 1842. It is widely read as an expression of Tennyson's grief over the death of his close friend Arthur Henry Hallam. The poem, made up of four quatrains, is spoken by someone standing on a rocky seashore, watching the waves break endlessly against the stones while he struggles to put his sorrow into words.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*Break, break, break,
On thy cold gray stones, O Sea!
And I would that my tongue could utter
The thoughts that arise in me.*

Paraphrasing:

The speaker watches the waves ceaselessly crash against the cold, grey rocks of the shore and wishes that he could find the words to express the overwhelming thoughts and grief rising up inside him.

Stanza 2:

*O, well for the fisherman's boy,
That he shouts with his sister at play!
O, well for the sailor lad,
That he sings in his boat on the bay!*

Paraphrasing:

He envies the simple, carefree happiness of the people around him – a fisherman's boy playing and shouting joyfully with his sister, and a young sailor singing cheerfully as he rows his boat – because their untroubled joy is so unlike his own inner sorrow.

Stanza 3:

*And the stately ships go on
To their haven under the hill;
But O for the touch of a vanish'd hand,
And the sound of a voice that is still!*

Paraphrasing:

He watches grand ships sail calmly onward toward their harbour, but their steady, unbroken progress only deepens his pain, for he longs desperately for the touch of a hand that is gone and the sound of a voice that has fallen silent forever through death.

Stanza 4:

*Break, break, break
At the foot of thy crags, O Sea!
But the tender grace of a day that is dead
Will never come back to me.*

Paraphrasing:

The waves go on breaking endlessly at the foot of the sea's rocky cliffs, but the speaker realises with quiet finality that the tender happiness of a vanished, irrecoverable day – like the loved one he has lost – can never come back to him.

Rhyming Scheme

The poem is written in four quatrains that follow an ABCB rhyme scheme – only the second and fourth lines of each stanza rhyme (for example, *Sea / me*), while the first and third lines remain unrhymed. The metre is irregular, largely trimeter, giving the poem a broken, halting rhythm that echoes the repeated, restless crashing of the waves and the speaker's own unresolved grief.

Theme

“Break, Break, Break” explores grief and the pain of irrecoverable loss, set against the backdrop of nature's indifferent, unending continuity. While the sea, the ships, and ordinary people's lives go on exactly as before, the speaker's private world has been permanently altered by death. The poem's central sorrow is that no happiness, once lost, can ever fully return – “the tender grace of a day that is dead / Will never come back to me.”

Figures of Speech

• Repetition / Anaphora

The title phrase “Break, break, break” opens and closes the poem, imitating the ceaseless, repetitive crashing of the waves.

• Apostrophe

The speaker directly addresses the sea throughout the poem (“O Sea!”), as if it could listen and respond.

• Symbolism

The sea represents the relentless, indifferent continuity of time and nature; the “vanish'd hand” and “voice that is still” symbolise the friend he has lost.

• Contrast

The carefree joy of the fisherman's boy and sailor lad is sharply contrasted with the speaker's private, unspoken grief.

• Imagery

Vivid visual and auditory imagery – cold gray stones, stately ships, breaking waves – builds the poem's sombre, reflective mood.

- **Alliteration**

Phrases such as “sings...boat” and “haven...hill” use repeated sounds to add musicality to the lines.

Questions & Answers

Q1. What does the speaker wish he could do at the start of the poem?

He wishes he could put into words (“utter”) the overwhelming thoughts and grief that rise up within him as he watches the sea.

Q2. Whom does the speaker envy in the second stanza, and why?

He envies the fisherman's boy playing with his sister and the sailor lad singing in his boat, because their carefree happiness contrasts with his own inner sorrow.

Q3. What does the speaker miss most, according to the third stanza?

He misses “the touch of a vanish'd hand” and “the sound of a voice that is still” – the physical presence of someone he has lost to death.

Q4. What is the effect of the repeated phrase “Break, break, break”?

It mimics the endless, repetitive rhythm of the waves and reflects the speaker's own unrelieved, recurring grief.

Q5. What final realisation does the speaker reach in the last stanza?

He realises that “the tender grace of a day that is dead” – a happiness now past – can never return, however steadily the sea and the world continue on.

Q6. Whose death is the poem generally believed to mourn?

It is widely read as an elegy for Tennyson's close friend, Arthur Henry Hallam, who died young.